BioSpecInfo

A guide for the people who use it — BioSpecInfo

Samuele Pio Provenzano

Versione **bsi-v218** · commit `7c7dc6d`

Generato il 2026-10-16

Documento generato automaticamente dal sorgente Markdown versionato nel repository. La versione e il commit stampati in ogni piè di pagina identificano esattamente lo stato del software descritto.

A guide for the people who use it — BioSpecInfo

This guide is written for people who study, not for people who program. You do not need to know anything about computing.

What it is

BioSpecInfo is an application for studying chemistry, biochemistry, pharmacology and astrochemistry. It opens like a website, but you can **install** it on your phone or computer and it works **without internet** too.

Three things to know straight away:

- **No sign-up needed.** No account, no email, no password.
- **It costs nothing.**
- **Your data stay yours.** Notes, files and conversations never leave your

device: there is no server they could reach.

👉 **samupropio1-ship-it.github.io/BioSpecInfo-v11**

Installing it (optional, but worth it)

Installing gives you an icon on your screen, full-screen opening and offline operation.

Device	How to do it
Android / Chrome	⋮ menu → *Install app* (or *Add to Home screen*)
iPhone / iPad	Share button → *Add to Home Screen*
Computer	Install icon in the address bar, on the right

After installing, open the app once with the network on: it will download everything it needs. From then on it works with no signal too.

Finding your way around

Element	Where it is	What it is for
🔍 **Search**	At the top	Searches the whole app. Shortcut: `Ctrl+K`
Section menu	Navigation bar	The 96 sections, grouped by subject
✨	Bottom right	Tools, settings and updates
Spectra	Bottom right	The assistant that answers questions

The things you will do most often

Analysing a molecule

1. Open the **Spectroscopy centre**
2. Type the molecule into the box. You can use:

- the **name** — `aspirin`, `caffeine`
- the **SMILES formula** — `CC(=O)Oc1ccccc1C(=O)O`
- or **draw it** with the editor

1. Press Enter

You get the 2D and 3D structure, the functional groups, the molecular weight, the predicted spectra (IR, NMR, mass, UV-Vis) and the pharmacological properties.

> **If you have no network:** searching by *name* does not work, because it has to consult an external database. The SMILES formula, on the other hand, always works.

Reading an IR spectrum

The spectrum is drawn as on a real instrument: the scale at the bottom runs from 4000 to 400 cm^{-1} (**from left to right the numbers go down**) and the bands point **downwards**.

The coloured area below 1500 cm^{-1} is the **fingerprint region**: that is where the specific molecule is recognised, not just its class. Below the chart you will find the list of bands with their assignment.

> The spectra are **predicted** from the structure, not measured in a laboratory. They are there to help you recognise functional groups and to understand the link between structure and spectrum. For experimental data, the app sends you to the official databases.

Everything about spectra, in one place

What you do with a spectrum used to live in **nine sections** across two different menus. Now there is 🔬 **Spectra centre**, a single section with ten tabs:

tab	what it is for
Read your spectrum	a file, a photo, a PDF
Predict NMR	^{1}H and ^{13}C assigned per atom
2D NMR and NOE	COSY, HSQC, HMBC
Mass	fragmentation and neutral losses
IR	bands and functional groups
UV-Vis	chromophores and λmax
Reference tables	^{1}H, ^{13}C, IR, J constants

tab	what it is for
Everything on one molecule	editor, spectra, groups, comparison
Elucidate a structure	from the data to a proposal
Practise	recognise the group from the spectrum

The panels are the same ones as before: they were **moved**, not copied — there is no second copy of anything. The old links still work: if something in the application used to take you to "Mass spectrum", it now opens the Spectra centre on the **Mass** tab.

> **Two tables of J constants, with different numbers.** There were two: one gave the aromatic ortho ^{3}J as 6–9 Hz, the other as 7–10. Whoever looked that number up got a different answer depending on where they came in. **One** remains, the one inside the Spectra centre, which sits in the section with its own reference list.

Changing language: the round button, top right

At the title's height, at the far right, there is a **round button** with the flag of the language in use. It opens into a **disc**: the fourteen flags on two shells — six inside, like a benzene ring, and eight outside — and at the centre appears the name of the language you are moving to and **how much it is translated**. That percentage is not hand-written: it is measured by applying the dictionary and counting what stays in Italian.

Touch a flag and the interface changes at once. `Esc` closes the disc.

> The 🌍 **Language** section remains, and does something else: it explains the languages, shows each one's coverage and says that Arabic carries the writing direction with it. That one **informs**, this one **acts**.

🎮 The Element Run

A retro platformer, in its own section. The power-ups are not flowers: they are **periodic table elements**, and each one transforms you with an ability that comes from its chemistry.

element	what it gives you	why
H	you jump higher	the lightest there is
He	you fall slowly	noble gas lighter than air
C	four shots in a fan	four bonds
F	the hardest shot	the most electronegative
Al	you take one hit	it passivates with its own oxide
Fe	you smash through falling	heavy and ferromagnetic
Hg	you run	liquid metal
Au	oxidising enemies cannot touch you	it does not oxidise

…and twelve more. Name and atomic number are read from **this application's periodic table**: they are not rewritten in the game.

Twelve levels in four zones, a **boss** at the end of each zone and the **final boss** at the twelfth. Levels are generated at random every run, but never impassable: no gap wider than a jump covers, no step higher than a jump clears — and before every boss you are guaranteed a shooting element, because a boss without one would be invincible.

Controls: `◄ ►` move, `⤒` jumps (hold it to jump higher), `✦` uses the element's ability. Keyboard: arrows or `A/D`, space jumps, `K` acts. Jumping **on** an enemy squashes it.

The five difficulties have chemistry names, and they are not decorative — they say how reactive the system is:

difficulty	what changes
Dilute solution	5 lives, everything slow, basic questions
Saturated solution	4 lives, more enemies and more power-ups
Exothermic reaction	3 lives, and **a wrong answer costs**
Enzymatic catalysis	2 lives, everything faster, 25 s to answer
Nuclear fusion	**one life**, fierce enemies, 20 s to answer

At the checkpoints (the flags) a chemistry question arrives. The difficulty does not make the same question harder: it changes **which** questions come — from an element's symbol to the right retrosynthetic disconnection for a target, by way of IR bands, ^{1}H and ^{13}C shifts, J constants, degrees of unsaturation, masses, reactions, amino acids and chemical languages.

> **The questions are not written in the game.** They are **generated** from this application's tables, and after each answer I tell you **where** that question comes from. If the table is right, the question is right — and there is no second list of chemistry that could diverge from the real ones.

It works offline: there is not a single file to download — the graphics are drawn as rectangles and the sounds are synthesised.

Where things are

The sections live in the **navigation bar**, grouped by subject, with 🛠️ **Utility** among them: laboratory, GHS, concept map, molecule comparison, molecule search, atlas, resources, materials, notes, file manager, statistics, data science, pomodoro, lab calculator, **articles**, and the two language ones.

The ✨ menu holds only what is *not* a section: the editors, the overlay labs, and actions such as exporting a figure, printing, sharing, updating. The rule is simple and always holds: **if something is in the bar, it is not also in the menu**. It used not to be, and the menu showed two "Data Science", two "File Manager", two "Articles" and two "Updates".

Two exceptions, and they have a reason:

- **Spectra** is not in the bar: it has its own dedicated button, the pulsing

one at the bottom. Three roads to the copilot were too many.

- The **spectrum reader** is not in the bar: it is a tab of the Spectra centre.

> **Two File Managers, and they are two different things.** In the bar, 📁 **File Manager** is for uploading and organising your own notes (PDF, images, Word). In the ✨ menu, 🔒 **Protected File Manager** is a separate page with the password, for the gallery and the custom sections. They had the same name and looked like a duplicate: now they are named for what they do.

The articles and the Nobel Prizes

📰 **Articles** (from the ✨ menu) has two tabs.

Latest articles shows what came out in the last two months, by topic: spectroscopy, synthesis, catalysis, drugs, materials, biochemistry, computational. It is not a hand-written list — that would be stale tomorrow: it comes from **Crossref**, the DOI registry, at the moment you open the tab. Each title leads to its **DOI**, which is a permanent address, and beside it there is a link to **read it in Italian**.

Nobel Prize in Chemistry lists every prize. Years, laureates and motivations come from the **Nobel Foundation**, live: they are not written inside the application. The **explanation** in Italian is — and it is matched to the *topic* of the official motivation, not to the year, so no attribution comes from here. For each prize you get the official page, the Foundation's scientific and popular material, the Italian translated view and an Italian Wikipedia search — all addresses **computed** from the year, not written.

> **If a prize has no explanation, I say so.** I would rather write "for this prize I have no explanation" and leave you the official motivation and the Foundation's material, which is the source, than make something up.

> **It needs the network.** Without it you do not see a stale list passed off as current: you see what I asked for, from whom, and why it did not arrive — with the address of the request, which you can open by hand.

Reading a spectrum you measured yourself

The **Spectrum reader** section does the opposite of the one above: it does not predict a spectrum from a structure, it reads one you already have.

There are **two buttons**, and they are not duplicates.

`📂 Open a file` filters nothing: whatever you have in your folder, open it. `📷 Photo or image of a spectrum` instead opens the **phone gallery** and also lets you take the picture there and then — on a phone these are two different system pickers, not two filters of the same one, and without the second there is no way to hand over a photograph.

A line under the buttons then **tells you what it decided the file is**:

What you open	What happens
a **PDF**, a **Word** file, an OpenDocument, a spreadsheet	it opens, shows you all of it and **works through** what it contains
a **photograph** (`.png` , `.jpg` , …)	both things: the **trace** is extracted and the image is also shown as a page, because it may be a photo of a spectrum or of a sheet
a **JCAMP-DX** (`.jdx` , `.dx`), compressed form included	it is a spectrum: the format itself says so
a **text** file or a `.csv`	decided **from the content**: if the numbers form a curve it is a spectrum, otherwise it is **problem text** and gets worked through

If you prefer, **paste** the data or the problem text into the box and press **Read and work it out**: the same reasoning applies.

> There used to be two cards, and the spectrum one allowed only `.jdx` and `.csv` . On a phone that filter did not narrow, it **hid**: anyone arriving with the PDF of an exam saw an empty folder. Now there is one door and it filters nothing.

If you have no file at hand, the three buttons **IR example**, **MS example** and **NMR example** load a sample spectrum, and **example: an exam problem** loads a complete problem.

Inside the section there is 📖 **How to use it — full guide**: seven short chapters covering the two buttons step by step, the calibration, what the program does by itself, what it cannot do, how to recognise a wrong result from the symptom you see, and how to take the numbers away.

A spectrum you only have as a figure

The trace is extracted from the **pixels**, and the chart appears at once. Then it must be **calibrated**, because the axis numbers are not in the image:

field	what you write in it
x at left / x at right	the values at the two edges of the plot — for an IR typically 4000 and 400 **in that order**, because an IR is written with decreasing wavenumbers
y at bottom / y at top	the values of the vertical axis; for a figure in %T, 0 at the bottom and 100 at the top
y unit	`%T` , `T` , `A` or intensity. Picking `%T` derives the absorbance with **$A = -\log_{10} T$**, which is the definition
x/y logarithmic	if an axis is logarithmic, say so: applying a linear map to it does not raise an error, it produces wrong numbers that look right
frame	normally I find it; "the whole figure" is for when the image is already cropped to the plot only

Change a field and the chart redraws by itself: there is nothing to confirm. Below it the **diagnostics** appear — how many columns, whether the frame was found and on which sides, background and threshold, how many columns were grid — because a number without its how cannot be challenged.

What I do by myself: I find the **axis frame** and digitise only what is inside it (the numbers written on the axes are dark pixels just like the trace); I **survive the grid**, picking in each column the run near where the trace was a pixel earlier and dark enough to be the trace; I read at **sub-pixel**, because the centre of a two-pixel line sits in between.

> **How much I get wrong.** Measured over seven constructed figures whose band centres are known: **mean 2.2 cm⁻¹** deviation, **worst 7.3**. One column of a figure 900 pixels wide over 3600 cm⁻¹ is worth about 4 cm⁻¹: below that there is nothing to gain, it is the limit of the figure.

> **If the calibration is wrong**, the peaks come out at wrong numbers while sitting in the right place on the figure: the shape is recovered from the pixels, the calibration is not. And a photo taken at an angle carries a distortion I do not straighten — frame the figure head-on.

With **download CSV** and **download JCAMP-DX** the numbers leave this place: any spectroscopy program opens the JCAMP, and this very reader reads it back identical. Inside it is written that the calibration was given by hand.

Below the chart you will find the peaks found with their signal-to-noise ratio, and for each band **all** compatible assignments. If you read two rows at 1715 cm⁻¹, that is not a defect: at that wavenumber a ketone and a carboxylic acid are both possible, and naming only one would be inventing.

> The reader **does not tell you which molecule it is**. A set of bands is compatible with many different molecules: the step from spectrum to structure is yours to take, with everything else you know about the sample.

Opening a problem and having it worked through

The same button, `📂 Open a file`. It takes the PDF of the exam, a photograph of the sheet, a Word file, plain text — and shows you **everything** inside: every page drawn (click to enlarge) and the full text.

Then, if the text contains spectroscopic data, it recognises them and puts them in a table **with where it took each one from**. That table sits above the working on purpose: look at it first. If it mistook a mass for an IR band, the working that follows will be impeccable and the answer wrong, and you catch it there.

The working lists the steps with the **evidence** for each and how certain it is: degrees of unsaturation are arithmetic, the carbon count from the M+1 peak is an estimate with a margin, an IR band is *compatible with* several things.

> **It does not give you the structure.** A set of spectroscopic data is compatible with more than one molecule, and a program producing a single one would offer a certainty the data do not contain. What you can do is the opposite: write a structure yourself and the program **compares** it, signal by signal, saying where it fails.

> **If the document is a scan**, the text cannot be read: a scanned page contains pixels, not letters, and there is no optical character recognition. The app tells you instead of pretending the sheet was empty. The pages stay visible, and if one is a photograph of a spectrum the trace can be extracted with **Open an image**.

Choosing the language

The **Languages** section holds **fourteen** languages, with a search field to find them quickly: Italian, English, Spanish, French, German, Portuguese, Dutch, Polish, Romanian, Greek, Russian, Chinese, Japanese and Arabic. Choosing Arabic also flips the page's **direction**, right to left.

Next to it is **Chemical languages**, which is a different thing: it converts a molecule among the twenty-five notations chemistry writes it in — SMILES, InChI, SMARTS, molfile, XYZ, PDB, CML, the fingerprints — and, for a declared class of simple molecules, writes its **IUPAC name**. Outside that class it says so, rather than attempting a wrong name.

Studying with cards

1. Open the study section
2. Generate a deck of cards
3. For each card, after answering, say how well you remembered it

The app works out **when** to show it to you again: the things you know well come back rarely, the uncertain ones come back soon. When you reopen, you only find the cards that are due.

Looking up a drug

Open **Pharmacology**. For each of the 263 drugs you will find the structure, molecular weight, mechanism of action, indications, adverse effects and class.

> ⚕ **For teaching purposes only.** This information does not replace the judgement of a doctor or a pharmacist, and is not there to decide a therapy.

Spectra, the assistant

Spectra answers chemistry questions and can use the app's own tools: calculate, generate spectra, look up constants, balance reactions.

Getting it working

Spectra relies on an external artificial-intelligence service, and you need a free **key**. Two routes:

The simplest — a key of your own

1. Go to console.groq.com and create a key

(free, it takes two minutes)

1. Open Spectra, paste the key into the 🔑 box
2. Done

The definitive one — a proxy

If services often fail to answer for you, or you would rather not keep the key on your phone, you can publish a *proxy*: a small free program that keeps the key safe and makes even the services that are blocked from the browser work.

In the assistant's **Proxy** box you will find **"How to set it up, in 4 steps"**, with the commands ready to copy.

When Spectra does not answer

Almost always it is not the app's fault but the external service's. Press 🔌 **Test** in Spectra's panel: in a few seconds it tells you **which services your device can actually reach** — and you need no key to find out.

If a service stops answering, Spectra remembers it for 24 hours and moves it to the bottom of the list, under *"Did not answer from this device"*. It does not delete it: tomorrow it might work again.

The File Manager

A personal archive for photos, documents and HTML pages, protected by a password.

> ⚠️ **Something you need to know.** This protection is a **deterrent**, not real security: whoever knows where to look can get around it. Do not put confidential documents in it.

The files stay on your device. **There is no copy anywhere else:** if you clear your browser data or change phone, they are gone. Use the export for the things you care about.

Frequently asked questions

Do I have to pay for anything? No. The app is free. If you use Spectra, the AI service's free key has daily limits, but nothing is paid.

Does it really work without internet? Yes, after the first opening. The only things left out are those that by their nature have to ask someone else: searching molecules by name, 3D structures downloaded on the spot, and Spectra.

Are my notes saved somewhere? Only on your device. There is no server: nobody can read them, but nobody can recover them for you either if you lose them.

How do I delete my data? ✨ menu → Settings → delete data. You can choose **what**: only the keys, only the conversations, only the study data, or everything.

I updated but I do not see anything new. ✨ menu → **Updates** → *Check*. There you can also see which version you are running.

Can I trust the spectra for a report? For recognising functional groups and understanding the structure-spectrum relationship, yes. For a figure to be cited as experimental, no: they are predictions. The app sends you to the official databases (NIST, SDBS) with direct links.

I found an error in a chemical datum. Report it: open an *issue* on the GitHub repository. The data go through automatic checks, but no check finds everything.

If something goes wrong

Problem	What to try
The app does not open	Reload it. If it persists, ✨ menu → Updates → Check
I do not see the new features	The version is in the ✨ menu → Updates
Spectra does not answer	The 🔌 **Test** button: it tells you which services you reach
"Out of space"	✨ menu → Settings → delete the old conversations
A section stays empty	Check the network: some sections load data from the internet
The charts are blurred	Reload the page; the charts are redrawn at your screen's resolution

---

Contacts

Author: Samuele Pio Provenzano **Repository and reports:** github.com/samupropio1-ship-it/BioSpecInfo-v11

Guide updated to version `bsi-v218`.